Abdulghani "Gerry" Ajul Salapuddin

Abdulghani "Gerry" Ajul Salapuddin (born March 25, 1952) is a Filipino statesman, institutional leader, and legislator from Basilan Province whose life story traces the arc of modern Moro history: from guerrilla commander in the hills of Basilan, to three-term Governor, to Congressman and Deputy Speaker of the House of Representatives, and now as the Administrator and Chief Executive Officer of the Southern Philippines Development Authority (SPDA).

He is Yakan, the predominant indigenous Muslim ethnolinguistic group native to Basilan, and has spent his public life advocating for the rights, development, and recognition of Moro communities within the Philippine republic.

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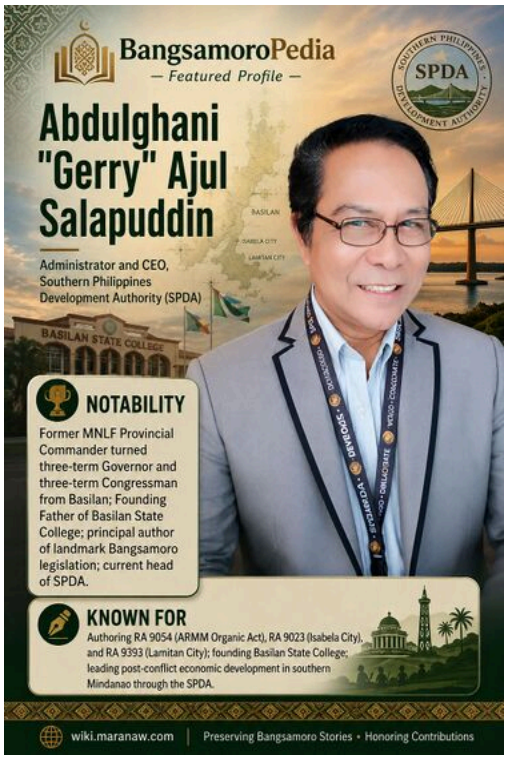
EARLY LIFE

Salapuddin was born on March 25, 1952, in Tuburan, Muhammad Ajul Municipality, Basilan Province, a small coastal settlement on Basilan Island in the Sulu Archipelago.

His early academic record was strong. He topped his class from Grades 1 to 5 at Tuburan Elementary School and graduated as class valedictorian in 1966.

For high school, he enrolled at Basilan City High School (BCHS), transferred to Lamitan Barangay High School (LBHS) for his second and third year (1968–1970), then returned to BCHS, completing secondary education with honors in 1972.

Abdulghani "Gerry" Ajul Salapuddin



Personal Information

Born: March 25, 1952
Tuburan, Muhammad Ajul Municipality, Basilan Province, Philippines

Ethnicity

Yakan (Basilan)

Religion

Islam (Sunni)

Education

AB Political Science, Western Mindanao State University (WMSU) / Basilan State College (BaSC), 1990
Master in Public Administration (MPA), BaSC
Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.), BaSC

Current Position

Like many young Moro men coming of age in the 1960s and early 1970s, Salapuddin grew up amid escalating tension between Moro communities and the Philippine state. When family circumstances made college financially impossible, he joined the armed struggle rather than set aside his aspirations entirely.

REVOLUTIONARY YEARS: MNLF COMMANDER

In the early 1970s, Salapuddin joined the **Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF)**, the main armed movement fighting for Moro self-determination under the leadership of Nur Misuari.

He served as an active combatant and commander in both land and sea operations across Basilan and the Zamboanga Peninsula, eventually rising to the rank of **Provincial Revolutionary Commander** for Basilan. Within the MNLF, he was known by the revolutionary alias **"Faihk."**

In 1984, after more than a decade in the field, Salapuddin returned to mainstream civilian life. According to the official SPDA biographical record, his first act upon reintegrating was to request from then-President Ferdinand Marcos the establishment of a state college in Basilan and a scholarship program, because he wanted to give the youth of Basilan the very educational opportunity that conflict had denied him.

EDUCATIONAL BACKGROUND

Salapuddin pursued higher education while simultaneously building his political career, a reflection of the same persistence that defined his earlier years.

He enrolled at **Western Mindanao State University (WMSU)** in Zamboanga City, completing three years of college (1985–1988) before transferring to **Basilan State College (BaSC)**, where he finished his **Bachelor of Arts in Political Science** in 1990.

He then completed his graduate and post-graduate studies entirely at BaSC, earning a **Master in Public Administration (MPA)** and a **Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.)**.

Administrator and CEO, Southern Philippines Development Authority (SPDA)
Appointed: February 2, 2018

Political Career

Executive Council Member, Regional Autonomous Government (RAG) Region IX (1984–1986)
Governor of Basilan (1988–1998)
Representative, Lone District of Basilan (1998–2007)
Deputy Speaker, House of Representatives, 12th and 13th Congress (2002–2007)

Party Affiliation

Lakas–CMD; previously LAMMP (1998–2001)

Notability

Former MNLF Provincial Commander turned three-term Governor and three-term Congressman from Basilan; Founding Father of Basilan State College; principal author of landmark Bangsamoro legislation; current head of SPDA.

Known For

Authoring RA 9054 (ARMM Organic Act), RA 9023 (Isabela City), and RA 9393 (Lamitan City); founding Basilan State College; leading post-conflict economic development in southern Mindanao through the SPDA.

He also attended international programs, including a 1989 Regional Development Management course at the **Asian Institute of Management (AIM)** in Makati, and a 1992 fellowship on Local Autonomy in **Berlin, Germany**.

POLITICAL AND INSTITUTIONAL CAREER

Regional Autonomous Government (1984–1986)

After returning from the field, Salapuddin served as a member of the **Executive Council of the Regional Autonomous Government (RAG) of Region IX** in Zamboanga City from 1984 to 1986. This transitional body was part of the government's effort to integrate returning MNLF commanders into formal governance structures.

Governor of Basilan (1988–1998)

In 1988, Salapuddin won the governorship of Basilan, unseating an incumbent in a close election. He served **three consecutive terms** spanning a full decade (1988–1998).

His tenure coincided with some of the most difficult years for Basilan, a province contending with the remnants of armed conflict, deep poverty, and limited infrastructure. He is credited with stabilizing local governance, accelerating rural infrastructure construction, and negotiating local peace compacts that helped bring brief but meaningful periods of economic activity to the island in the 1990s.

One of his signature accomplishments during this period was the founding of **Basilan State College (BaSC)**, which he established to provide accessible, affordable higher education to Basilan's youth. The college now operates multiple campuses across the province, including in Isabela City, Lamitan City, Maluso, and Tipo-Tipo. More than 5,000 scholarship grantees have passed through the institution.

House of Representatives (1998–2007)

After completing his gubernatorial terms, Salapuddin ran for and won the congressional seat for the **Lone District of Basilan**, serving three consecutive terms from 1998 to 2007.

His colleagues elected him **Deputy Speaker of the House of Representatives** during the 12th and 13th Congresses (2002–2007), a recognition of his standing among Mindanao's legislative bloc.

In Congress, he authored and championed several landmark laws that significantly shaped the legal and institutional landscape of Muslim Mindanao:

- **Republic Act 9054** (2001): The amended Organic Act of the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM), the foundational law expanding the region's autonomy.
- **Republic Act 9023**: The law that converted Isabela into a city, creating **Isabela City**, now the most populous urban center in Basilan.
- **Republic Act 9393**: The law that created **Lamitan City**, the second city in the province.
- **National Commission for Muslim Filipinos (NCMF)**: Salapuddin is credited as the original author of the law establishing this key national agency for Muslim Filipino affairs.
- **Basilan Circumferential Road (BCR)**: He authored the legislation that nationalized the BCR, placing responsibility for the road under the national government.

His congressional career was not without controversy. A bitter political rivalry with the Akbar clan culminated when Congressman Wahab Akbar (who had succeeded him as Governor of Basilan) was assassinated in a bombing at the Batasan Pambansa complex in November 2007. Salapuddin was among those initially linked to the incident but was subsequently cleared of involvement.

Administrator and CEO, SPDA (2018–Present)

On **February 2, 2018**, President Rodrigo Duterte appointed Salapuddin as the **13th Administrator and CEO** of the **Southern Philippines Development Authority (SPDA)**, a government-owned and controlled corporation mandated to promote agro-industrial development in Mindanao and the Sulu Archipelago.

He assumed office on February 6, 2018.

Under his leadership, the SPDA has been repositioned as an active facilitator of agricultural investment and public-private partnership. Key initiatives under his tenure include:

- Developing a **halal feed industry hub** and strengthening food security infrastructure across the Bangsamoro region.
- Advocating for the rescue of Basilan's struggling rubber industry, including proposals for modern rubber processing plants and financial assistance for agrarian cooperatives.
- Facilitating joint-venture discussions with agro-industrial investors, including explorations of abaca and palm oil development in SPDA landholdings in Lanao del Sur and Basilan.
- Brokering inter-agency dialogues between the national government and the **Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)** to resolve land proclamation disputes and support the establishment of economic zones.
- Relocating and upgrading the SPDA's main office in Davao City to a larger, modernized facility in Catalunan Pequeño in 2022.

Salapuddin has also championed SPDA's role as a peace dividend institution, framing agricultural development as inseparable from the consolidation of peace in the Bangsamoro.

RECOGNITION AND AWARDS

Salapuddin's transition from armed combatant to institution builder has earned him recognition at the national level.

- **Honorary Public Servant of the Year (2024)**: Awarded at the **Nation Builders and Mosliv Awards** held at Okada Manila, for excellence in Peace and Nation Building.
- **Basilan Exemplary Leadership Recognition**: Honored by the Provincial Government of Basilan for his foundational contributions to the province's governance and geographic development, particularly the conversion of Isabela and Lamitan into cities.

LEGACY AND SIGNIFICANCE

Gerry Salapuddin's place in Bangsamoro history is distinctive precisely because of the full arc he has lived. He was not merely a witness to the Moro struggle but an active participant in its armed phase, then an architect of its political and legislative phase, and now one of its economic managers.

His founding of Basilan State College alone represents a concrete, lasting contribution to Yakan and Moro communities, providing a gateway to higher education on an island historically left behind in national development.

In Congress, his legislative fingerprints are on some of the most consequential laws affecting Muslim Mindanao: the expanded ARMM Organic Act, the creation of two Basilan cities, and the establishment of the NCMF. Each of these changed the institutional terrain of the region in ways that outlast any single political term.

More broadly, his career demonstrates what peace advocates often argue in the abstract: that former combatants can become credible, effective builders of the very state they once contested. In Salapuddin's case, that argument is not theoretical. It is a biography.

SEE ALSO

- Southern Philippines Development Authority (SPDA)
- Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF)
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)
- Basilan State College
- Yakan people

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